Hanqi Wang

Updated October 29, 2026

Vancouver School of Economics
University of British Columbia
6000 Iona Drive, Vancouver, BC V6T 1L4, Canada

hwang828@student.ubc.ca
+1 519 701 9993
hanqiwang-econ.github.io

Placement Officer Professor Raffaele Saggio rsaggio@mail.ubc.ca +1 604 822 1418
Graduate Programs Manager Devin Clemens econ.gradinfo@ubc.ca +1 604 822 4616

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, University of British Columbia — 2021 – May 2027 (expected)
M.A. in Economics, University of British Columbia — 2021
B.M.O.S. (Honors), Accounting and Economics, Western University — 2020

Fields

Primary Econometric Theory
Secondary Applied Econometrics; Microeconomic Theory

Job Market Paper

Estimating a Rational Inattention Discrete Choice Model: A Semiparametric Approach

Abstract. People's choices depend on both the payoffs of the available options and what they learn about those payoffs before deciding. This paper shows how choice data identify both unobserved payoff heterogeneity and the cost of information acquisition in a rational inattention discrete-choice model. I establish conditions for semiparametric point identification using exogenous payoff and information-cost shifters, without imposing parametric forms on the taste-shock distribution or on how the unit cost of information varies with observed characteristics. In the model with binary choice, I construct an unobserved choice threshold whose cumulative distribution function is the choice probability as a function of the payoff shifter. Moments of this threshold identify the payoff coefficients and the unit cost of information at each value of the information-cost shifter. A deconvolution argument then identifies the taste-shock distribution. I then extend identification to the model with multinomial choice. To estimate the model, I propose a sieve minimum-distance estimator based on observed market shares and establish its consistency. For inference, I construct confidence regions by test inversion because binding parameter constraints can make the estimator's limiting distribution nonnormal. In an application to Amazon Mechanical Turk, model counterfactuals show that lower unit costs of information raise the average task-taking probability and reduce wage elasticity.

References

Kyungchul Song *(co-advisor)*
Professor of Economics
Vancouver School of Economics
University of British Columbia
kyungchul.song@ubc.ca

Paul Schrimpf *(co-advisor)*
Associate Professor of Economics
Vancouver School of Economics
University of British Columbia
paul.schrimpf@ubc.ca

Vitor Farinha Luz
Associate Professor of Economics
Vancouver School of Economics
University of British Columbia
vitor.farinhaluz@ubc.ca

Fellowships and Awards

Four Year Doctoral Fellowship (4YF), University of British Columbia — 2022 – 2026
Board of Directors' Gold Medal, King's University College at Western University — 2020
Highest final-year average in the B.M.O.S. Honors program
Dean's Honor List, Western University — 2016 – 2019

Work in Progress

Directed Search with Rational Inattention

Abstract. This paper develops a directed search model for estimating workers' job preferences and information costs from application data. Workers observe firm types but not realized wages and choose what wage information to acquire before deciding where to apply. Information costs take the Shannon entropy form and can vary across worker types. I define a rationally inattentive search equilibrium in which application choices determine congestion across submarkets, while congestion shapes job-finding probabilities and the returns to information. I establish equilibrium existence when the wage distribution has finite support and job-finding probabilities depend continuously on workers' application probabilities. The proof's key insight is to use the linear-fractional structure of the generalized logit formula to establish existence without requiring a unique solution to workers' information-acquisition problems. I also establish conditions for identifying worker-type-specific information costs using twin job types with identical amenity values but different wages.

Identification of a Targeted Search Model for Two-sided Matching Markets

Abstract. Matching among similar people may reflect preferences or the composition of their social circles. I establish conditions for identifying preference and social-circle parameters from observed search behavior. Building on Cheremukhin et al. (2020, 2015), I develop a two-sided search model with unobserved payoff heterogeneity, allowing the value of a match to vary across individuals. Individuals choose how likely they are to contact each partner type, such as an education group. Social circles determine the probabilities of contacting each type without additional effort. A targeting cost captures the effort required to redirect search. Matches require reciprocal search. I establish equilibrium existence and show that social circles can generate matching among similar partners when targeting costs are high, even without a preference for similarity. Individual contact probabilities identify targeting costs through quantile comparisons that use a specified distribution of unobserved payoff heterogeneity. Observed social circles then allow recovery of preferences. When circles are unobserved, I give conditions under which changes in targeting costs identify both preferences and social-circle composition. When only average contact probabilities are observed for each type, I compare environments with different social circles but common preferences and targeting costs, and establish conditions for local identification of preferences and targeting costs.

Conference and Seminar Presentations

Econometric Society North American Summer Meeting, Emory University — June 2026
Canadian Economics Association Annual Conference, Simon Fraser University — May 2026

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Vancouver School of Economics, UBC

ECON 325	Introduction to Econometrics I	Summer 2026
ECON 425	Advanced Econometrics	Fall 2022, Spring 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026
ECON 327	Introduction to Empirical Methods	Fall 2023
ECON 301	Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis I	Spring 2023
ECON 102	Principles of Macroeconomics	Spring 2021
ECON 334	Economic History of Modern Europe	Fall 2020

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Professor Kyungchul Song, UBC — Sept 2024 – May 2025

Professional Service

Referee for *Journal of Econometric Methods* — 2026

Skills and Languages

Programming	Julia (structural estimation), Python, R, Stata, SQL
Languages	English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native)
Citizenship	People's Republic of China